Chapter 3

Oral Communication I & II

Learning objectives

- Develop communication skills: questions, complaints, persuasion, initiative, permission, invitations.
- Enhance self-awareness and build positive habits.

1. Oral Communication I - Functions

Introducing Oneself

- For any professional and technical discussion, the first step is getting to know names, followed by an exchange of personal information which will promote trust and confidence.

- Example – Case study
  - Mr Kumar is the CEO of ABC Corp. He has given the contract for the construction of a hexagonal building to XYZ Construction Corp. Mr Sagar, the chief architect of the company, enters the room.

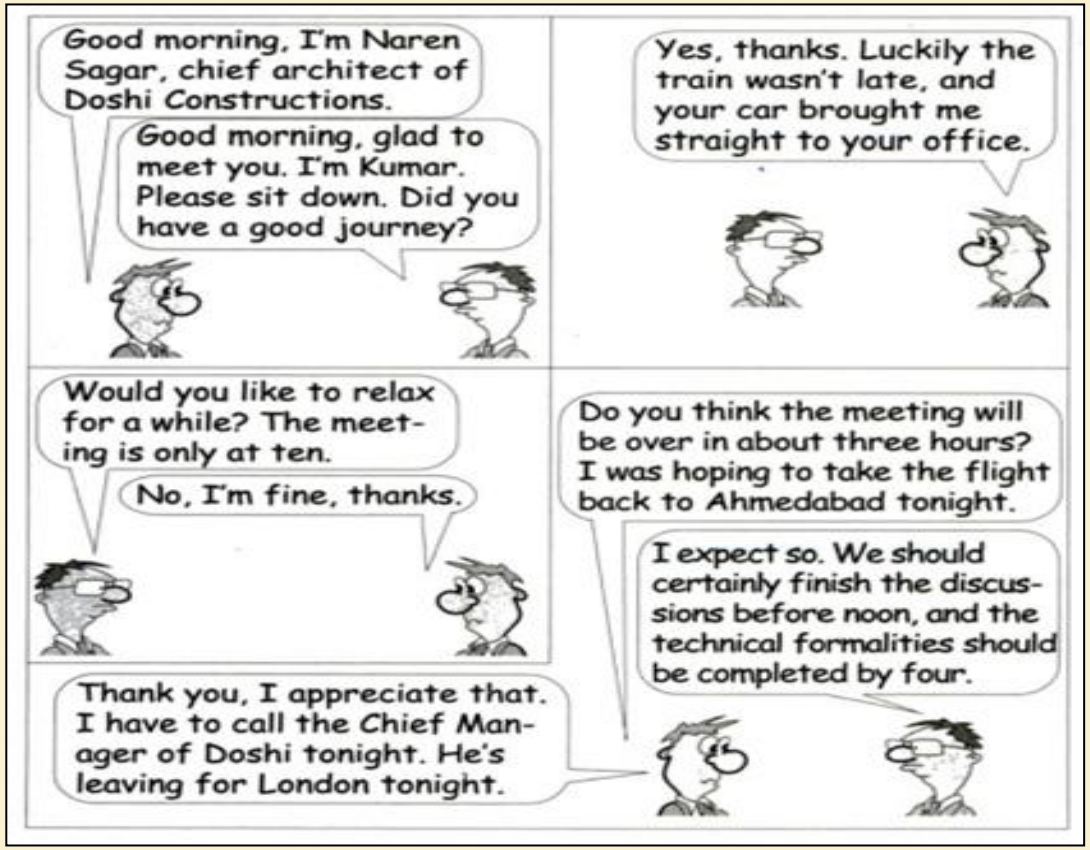

Figure 1: Example of introducing oneself. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Introducing Oneself (Cont.)

- At the beginning of the meeting, the Chief Executive says:
  - Good morning, everyone. Today, we are joined by Mr. Naren Sagar, Senior Architect from XYZ Construction Corp. He has been assigned the responsibility of constructing the hexagonal building, which will serve as our main administrative office. Before we begin the discussion, I would like to introduce him to everyone present here.
  - I am Mr. Peter Manual Kumar, Executive Director of the company, responsible for all organizational matters. This is Mr. James, Head of Administrative Services. Mr. Anand Kumaraswamy is the Head of the Finance Department, in charge of capital expenditure and maintenance. The third member of our team is Mr. Majid Ahmed, Project Supervisor. Now, shall we start the discussion?

Introducing Oneself - Language Talk

- Mr. Sultan Shah is a consultant in a computer firm. He is currently visiting M.J. Engineering College, Hyderabad, to establish a new quality control system. During his visit, he meets Dr. Joseph Fernandes, Head of the Department of Computer Science.
- **Task – Case study 1**
  - Read the following conversation between Mr. Sultan Shah and Mr. Joseph Fernandes. The dialogue of Mr. Fernandes has been left blank. Imagine what he might have said, and complete the conversation.

Introducing Oneself - Language Talk (Cont.)

Mr Shah	:	Good morning! I'm Sultan Shah from Bombay Computer Centre.
Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	It was quite comfortable, thank you.
Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	No, I've come here on many occasions in connection with my work. Recently we set up a quality control system at a local hospital. By the way, I do hope arrangements have been made for our stay.
Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	That's fine. We are five at present, but two or three may join us later.

Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	They will be here by the end of this month.
Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	It will take at least a month for us to complete the work.
Mr Fernandes	:	_____
Mr Shah	:	Thank you. I look forward to my stay here.

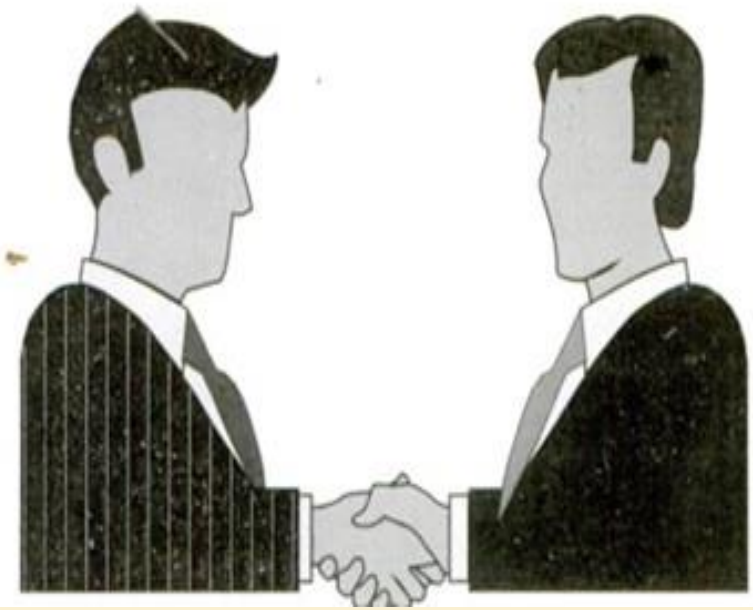

Figure 2: Example of language talk. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Introducing Oneself - Language Talk (Cont.)

Practice 1

You are the Head of the Department of Computer Science. A new staff member has joined your department. Introduce this person to the faculty members, clearly mentioning the specific duties and responsibilities of each staff member.

Your tasks:

- ❖5 - 10 members per group.
- ❖Discuss for 15 minutes.
- ❖Choose 3-5 members and assign roles to each member; Conduct your practice for 10 minutes on the stage.
- ❖The classmates vote on clarity, logic, and delivery.

Asking questions and giving polite replies

- Engineers interact with many people (clients, seniors, juniors, friends, strangers).
- Efficiency and talent alone are not enough ➔ must be ***friendly and polite***.
- Good communication skills build relationships and make work enjoyable.
- ***Non-verbal cues*** (smiles, gestures, body language) are important.
- Always use “please” when making requests.
- To get attention politely: *“Excuse me, sir” / “Pardon me”.*
- Avoid rude actions: snapping fingers, clapping, shouting.

Asking questions and giving polite replies (Cont.)

- ***Some expressions of politeness***
  - ❖ If it is not inconvenient…
  - ❖ If you don't mind…
  - ❖ I don't know if you will agree with me…
  - ❖ I would be happy if…
- ***Some polite question forms***
  - ❖ Would you mind if I…?
  - ❖ Would you mind helping…?
  - ❖ Would you like to have…
  - ❖ Could I speak to…, please?

Asking questions and giving polite replies (Cont.)

- A question is essentially meant for seeking information. It has also certain other functions, such as making a suggestion, a request, seeking permission or offering help.
  - ***Suggestion***: Would you like me to get you the newspaper?
  - ***Request***: Could you open the window, please?
  - ***Offering help***: Would you like me to carry your bag?
  - ***Inviting***: Would you like to come to the party?
  - ***Permission***: May I use your phone?

Asking questions and giving polite replies (Cont.)

- **Task – Case Study 2:** In the following dialogue between an actress and a press reporter, the reporter's questions are missing. Frame suitable questions.

Reporter	:	You are quite a popular actress. People like your acting. May I know whether you like the acting profession?
Actress	:	Yes, I do enjoy acting very much.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	I don't know. I haven't made any plans.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	I don't know how long I will act.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	I started acting when I was 15.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	My parents do like me acting in films.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	My real name is Geetha.
Reporter	:	
Actress	:	I live in Juhu and my parents are with me. Sorry, I have to attend a party tonight.
Reporter	:	

Figure 3: Example of the dialogue between an actress and a press reporter. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Complaining and apologising

- Sometimes you may feel dissatisfied with colleagues, subordinates, or equipment/machines.
- In such situations, it is important to be polite and not rude when making a complaint.
- You should not complain immediately → it is better to wait for a while before responding.
- Usually, the other party will apologise, and the problem will be resolved.

Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

- Here is an example of some students complaining to the proprietor of a hotel.

Joseph	:	*Sir, we would like to talk to you for a minute.*
Hotel proprietor	:	*By all means. What can I do for you?*
Joseph	:	*We are regular customers of your hotel. We come here practically every evening. We would like to bring to your notice the rude behaviour of one of your waiters.*
Hotel proprietor	:	*Let me have the details. I shall certainly do what is needed.*
Ramesh	:	*We have been sitting here for well over 20 minutes and he has not even bothered to attend on us.*
Joseph	:	*We called him twice but he said rudely, 'I shall come only when I am free.'*
Hotel proprietor	:	*I am extremely sorry for his behaviour.*
Ramesh	:	*The other day when we ordered snacks, he deliberately delayed our order. We had to wait for nearly half an hour. We are most unhappy about the service.*
Hotel proprietor	:	*I do apologise for his behaviour. I shall talk to him. Please be seated. I will send someone else to attend on you.*

Figure 4: Example of some students complaining to the proprietor of a hotel. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

- ***Some patterns of complaint***
  - ❖ I am sorry to bring to your notice…
  - ❖ I am afraid I have got a complaint…
  - ❖ I am not sure how to say this, but…
  - ❖ Would you mind listening to my complaint…
  - ❖ I am afraid I have got something to tell you…
  - ❖ I am not at all satisfied…
  - ❖ I take strong exception to…
  - ❖ I really must object to…
  - ❖ I wish to complaint in the strongest terms about…
  - ❖ Etc.

Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

- ***Some patterns of apology***
  - Sorry, my fault…
  - Please accept my apology for…
  - It was foolish/ silly/ careless/ stupid of me…
  - Please forgive me/ I am extremely sorry for…
  - I cannot tell you how sorry I am…
  - I feel bad about…
  - Excuse me/ pardon me…
  - I am so awful/ terribly sorry…

Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

- ***Some patterns of accepting an apology***
  - That's quite all right…
  - Please don't worry…
  - It doesn't matter at all…
  - Forget it…
  - Please don't feel bad about it…
  - There is no need to apologise…
  - That's really not necessary…

Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

Practice 2

You are a junior engineer at a computer company. One of your customers recently bought a laptop from you. She complains that the laptop is not working properly. Role-play a situation in which you apologize for the inconvenience caused and promise to fix the laptop. The customer walks in looking very angry but leaves with a smile.

Your tasks:

- ❖5 - 10 members per group.
- ❖Discuss for 15 minutes.
- ❖Choose 2 members and assign roles to each member; Conduct your practice for 10 minutes on the stage.
- ❖The classmates vote on clarity, logic, and delivery.

Persuading people to do something

- An engineer is sometime involved in negotiating a business deal. Successful negotiation depends on persuasive talk.
- *Some expressions used for persuasion.*
  - Why don't you…?
  - I think you would do well to…
  - The most sensible thing to do would be…
  - I think it would be a pity if you didn't…
  - I am hoping I can persuade you to change your mind…
  - Are you sure you cannot…?
  - Why don't you think about it?
  - Etc.

Persuading people to do something (Cont.)

- Here is a conversation between a professor and her colleague.

Professor	:	*Hello, Mr Prasad, what can I do for you?*
Arun	:	*I've come here to consult you about something. I've got a good job and would like to resign my present post.*
Professor	:	*Really? Aren't you happy here?*
Arun	:	*Of course I am. It is a pleasure to work with you, madam. I like the college too.*
Professor	:	*Then why do you want to leave the job?*
Arun	:	*I've been offered a job in an industrial firm.*
Professor	:	*Why don't you wait a little? Pay revision is expected next month.*
Arun	:	*I have been offered a much higher salary, madam.*
Professor	:	*I know that the salary is very attractive there. But money is not the only consideration. You have a good image in college. The students also like you very much. Do you think you would be happy there without your family?*
Arun	:	*I am allowed to take my family.*
Professor	:	*I don't think you would be happy in the industry after having spent more than a decade teaching. The most sensible thing would be to weigh the pros and cons of accepting the foreign assignment. I am also retiring by the end of the academic year. Don't you think you have a good chance of becoming the Head? I think it would be a pity if you didn't consider these facts. Of course, I don't want to stand in your way.*
Arun	:	*Well madam, what you say may be true. You are my well-wisher. Let me think it over again. Perhaps I could meet you on Monday?*

Figure 5: Example of a conversation between a professor and her colleague. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Persuading people to do something (Cont.)

Practice 3

You are the agent of a popular brand of washing machine. Persuade a reluctant customer to purchase the machine, highlighting its unique features.

Your tasks:

- ❖5 - 10 members per group.
- ❖Discuss for 15 minutes.
- ❖Choose 2 members and assign roles to each member; Conduct your practice for 10 minutes on the stage.
- ❖The classmates vote on clarity, logic, and delivery.

Taking the initiative

- In professional settings, new ideas or proposals must be presented clearly and politely.
- Acceptance depends on usefulness, feasibility, and presentation style.
- A good beginning is essential; first impressions matter.
- Suggestions should be:
  - ❖ Practical and realistic (not too ambitious).
  - ❖ Presented without disappointment if rejected.
  - ❖ Respectful of others' views and interests.
  - ❖ Don't overwhelm listeners—introduce the proposal gradually.
  - ❖ Allow time for others to think and respond.
  - ❖ Use polite expressions when starting suggestions.

Taking the initiative (Cont.)

- ***Some expressions used for making suggestions.***
  - May I suggest…?
  - Let me…
  - Would you mind if…?
  - Shall we…?
  - Why don't you/we…?
  - Could we…?
  - How about…?
  - I think we should…
  - What about…?
  - Etc.

Taking the initiative (Cont.)

- Meeting between the General Manager of a company and his colleagues.

General Manager	:	*Now we come to the last item on our agenda. The Head Office has sanctioned the purchases of a car. I would like to have your suggestions*
Charles	:	*That's great! We have been trying to get this sanction for the past two years.*
Sunil	:	*Why don't we go in for a dieselised Ambassador? It can easily accommodate five people.*
Abbas	:	*That's a good suggestion. But what about a Tata Sumo? It has certain advantages. For site inspection we generally travel 50–100 km, and to many other places we go in groups of six or seven. The Tata Sumo would be more comfortable.*
Sunil	:	*Won't it cost more?*
Abbas	:	*No doubt it costs 3.5 lakhs, but travelling in a Sumo won't be so arduous. Moreover, we could drive it even on rough roads.*
General Manager	:	*I haven't travelled in a Sumo, though my friends have always preferred it. But there is a problem. The Head Office has sanctioned us only Rs 3 lakh and a Sumo costs more than that!*
Abbas	:	*We could go in for the Ambassador as suggested by Charles. But sir, could we not write to the department asking them to raise the sanctioned amount? It's a long-term investment and the vehicle is good for all seasons.*
Charles	:	*That's a good idea. I agree with Mr Abbas. The Sumo is a vehicle for all occasions. We can request the Head Office to release more funds for the car.*
Manager	:	*Well! If all of you agree on this point, I shall write to the Head Office. Thank you.*

Figure 6: Example of meeting between the General Manager of a company and his colleagues. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Taking the initiative (Cont.)

Practice 4

You are the General Manager of a factory which is on strike. The workers demand a hike in their wages. They want double wages on holidays and an increase in the annual bonus. You are asked to give your suggestions. What suggestions will you make?

Your tasks:

- ❖5 - 10 members per group.
- ❖Discuss for 15 minutes.
- ❖Choose 3-5 members and assign roles to each member; Conduct your practice for 10 minutes on the stage.
- ❖The classmates vote on clarity, logic, and delivery.

Seeking permission

- Politeness is essential ➔ both in words and tone.
- Permission responses can be affirmative (granted) or negative (refused).
- Permission may be granted wholeheartedly or with conditions.
- If refusing:
  - ❖ Avoid being harsh.
  - ❖ Always give a reason for refusal.
  - ❖ In formal situations ➔ use polite language and a respectful tone.

Seeking permission (Cont.)

- The following dialogues are examples of how permission may be sought and how it is granted or rejected in a formal situation.

Dialogue 1

Prabhakar	:	*Excuse me, sir. Would you mind if I came in an hour late tomorrow?*
Head of Department	:	*Not at all. But do you have a lecture during the first hour?*
Prabhakar	:	*Yes sir, I do, but I can make alternative arrangements with Mr Sharma.*
Head of Department	:	*Yes, please do that.*

Dialogue 2

Lily	:	*If you don't mind, I'd like to sit here.*
Preeti	:	*Sorry, I'm afraid it's not possible. An elderly man has been sitting here. He has probably gone for some water.*
Lily	:	*That's all right. I'll find a place somewhere else.*

Figure 7: Example of seeking permission. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Seeking permission (Cont.)

- ***Some expressions for seeking permission***
  - Do you mind if I…?
  - Would it be possible…?
  - If you don't mind, I'd like to…
  - Would you have any objection to my…?
  - Could I please…?
  - Is it all right if I…?
- ***Some expressions for giving permission***
  - Yes, of course.
  - Oh, sure.
  - Yes, certainly.
  - By all means. Go ahead.
  - That's perfectly all right.
  - I can't see any objection.
- ***Some expressions for refusing permission***
  - I am afraid it's not possible.
  - I'm sorry I can't let you.
  - I'm sorry I'm not supposed to.
  - Sorry, but you can't.
  - Permission will not be granted, I'm afraid.

Inviting friends and colleagues

- An invitation should show that we genuinely want the person to come.
- The guest should feel that their presence is important.
- Formal invitations ➔ for elders and officials.
- Informal invitations ➔ for friends; can be more relaxed and persuasive.

Inviting friends and colleagues (Cont.)

- Here is a dialogue between two friends.

Arjun	:	*I've bought two tickets for 'Jurassic Park'. Would you like to join me?*
Anita	:	*Which show?*
Arjun	:	*The evening show. We have to be at the theatre at 6 p.m.*
Anita	:	*I wish I could join you but I have to attend an important wedding reception. The bridegroom is my close relative. Thanks a lot for inviting me. I am, however, happy to go to the noon show.*
Arjun	:	*But we won't get tickets. I'll take Suresh with me for the evening show, in that case.*

Figure 7: Example of a dialogue between two friends. Source: Farhathullah, T. M. (2002). Communication Skills for Technical Students. Orient Longman.

Inviting friends and colleagues (Cont.)

- ***Some expressions for inviting people permission***
  - ❖ Would you like to…?
  - ❖ I would like to invite…
  - ❖ Why don't you…?
  - ❖ Would you mind…?
  - ❖ How about…?
  - ❖ Would you care to…?
- ***Some expressions for accepting an invitation***
  - ❖ Thank you.
  - ❖ What a wonderful/ splendid idea !
  - ❖ That sounds like a good idea.
  - ❖ We would be delighted.
  - ❖ That would give me the greatest pleasure.
  - ❖ Sure, thanks.
- ***Some expressions for refusing permission***
  - ❖ Thank you very much but…
  - ❖ I am terribly sorry…
  - ❖ Unfortunately…
  - ❖ I am afraid…
  - ❖ What a pity !
  - ❖ I regret I shall not be able to attend the party…
  - ❖ I shan't be…
  - ❖ That's very kind of you…
  - ❖ I would like to, but…

In conclusion

- Introducing Oneself.
- Asking questions and giving polite replies.
- Complaining and apologizing.
- Persuading people to do something.
- Taking the initiative.
- Seeking permission.
- Inviting friends and colleagues.

2. Oral Communication II - Situations

Know thyself

- Everyone should understand their strengths and weaknesses.
- Self-knowledge builds confidence to face life's challenges.
- Most people know very little about themselves.
- It is important to take time to reflect on your character and personality.

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

1. What is your nature? Express your opinion about each of these:
   - ❖ Are you shy and reserved, sociable, or aggressive?
   - ❖ Are you confident or hesitant?
   - ❖ Are you humble or proud?
   - ❖ Are you calm and collected, or sentimental and impulsive?
2. How do you behave with other people?
   - ❖ Do you like to start conversations with strangers?
   - ❖ Do you wait for others to talk to you first?
   - ❖ Do you prefer being surrounded by people?
   - ❖ Do you like to have many friends?

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

3. Talk briefly about your sleeping habits.
   - ❖ Do you usually sleep more than eight hours at night?
   - ❖ Do you enjoy sleeping or taking naps during the day?
   - ❖ Do you find it difficult to fall asleep at night?

4. What is your attitude toward work?
   - ❖ Do you like to stay active during the day?
   - ❖ Do you enjoy holidays?
   - ❖ Do you find it difficult to sit quietly?
   - ❖ Do you dislike being lazy or hate work?

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

5. How much attention do you pay to your appearance?
   - ❖ Do you like to wear the latest outfits?
   - ❖ Do you prefer to dress in a simple manner?
   - ❖ Do you take care of your face before going out?
   - ❖ Do you attach importance to make-up?
   - ❖ Do you have your hair cut once a month?

6. How practical are you?
   - ❖ Do you enjoy doing simple repairs at home?
   - ❖ Do you find it difficult to mend or fix things?
   - ❖ Do you prefer to do simple jobs by yourself?
   - ❖ Can you fix almost anything?

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

7. Which quality do your friends appreciate the most in you?
   - ❖ Your honesty?
   - ❖ Your cheerfulness?
   - ❖ Your generosity?
   - ❖ Your willingness to help?

8. How would you describe yourself?
   - ❖ Religious.
   - ❖ Active.
   - ❖ Practical.
   - ❖ Academic.
   - ❖ Jovial.

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

9. Which of the following would you prefer?
   - ❖ To have at least two close friends.
   - ❖ To have a number of acquaintances.
   - ❖ To have just one close friend.
   - ❖ To have five or six friends.

10. What situation would make you feel the most uneasy?
    - ❖ Being praised in front of others.
    - ❖ Being in a large crowd.
    - ❖ People laughing at you.
    - ❖ Seeing someone cry.

Know thyself (Cont.)

- ***Self-Expression Questions***

11. Which aspect of your life would you most like to improve?
    - Your looks.
    - Your attitude to work.
    - Your social life.
    - Your interest in current affairs.
    - Your relationship with your family.

Habits

- There are both good and bad habits. Good habits are to be cultivated, and bad ones given up.

Good Habits

1. Waking up early.
2. Exercising regularly.
3. Eating a balanced diet.
4. Reading every day.
5. Practicing time management.
6. Saving money.
7. Showing gratitude.
8. Active listening.
9. Etc.

Bad Habits

1. Playing loud music at night.
2. Watching television when others are asleep.
3. Talking all the time and not allowing others to talk.
4. Smoking in the presence of others.
5. Biting nails.
6. Losing the keys all the time.
7. Always coming late to college.
8. Cracking the finger points.
9. Etc.

In conclusion

- Know thyself.
- Habits.

Practice

Introducing Oneself - Language Talk (Cont.)

Practice 1

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Complaining and apologising (Cont.)

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THANK YOU
FOR YOUR ATTENTION

Q&A